

Level Up:

Another Game-creating Adventure

Create your own 3D puzzle/platform/adventure/whatever game with Atmosphir, then inflict it upon the world

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Making your own game isn't easy, even if you've got C code and 3D skills oozing out of every pore. Not surprising then, that we thought we'd run out of game-creation tools to tell you about. If game-creation tools were horses, we'd all be Bethesda. Or something like that, anyway.

But we were wrong. With a spanking new program called Atmosphir, you can create your own 3D platform game (like Mario, but with a whole extra D), share it with the Atmosphir community, and explore the games that others have created. The game engine is capable of some ridiculously complex levels, so there's much fun to be had.

But first, you must head to <http://atmosphir.com/download/> and sign yourself

up for the private (as of this writing) beta. Go ahead now; we'll wait.

Making the plan

Once you've got your beta invite and downloaded Atmosphir, you can get into Design mode to start creating your level. But first, you need to have a few things decided (don't worry if some things don't make sense yet; they will as we progress):

Firstly, where is your level going to take place? The current version of Atmosphir lets you create levels using three broad themes: a generic stone theme (the Adventure Pack), a forest theme (the Forest Treehouse Pack), and a desert theme (the Sand Castle Pack). You don't have to commit to any, though you can mix and match as much as you want. For now, let's settle for the regular Adventure Pack.

Secondly, what's the main challenge going to be? Will the player have to get from point A to point B, rack up a certain number

of points, defeat a number of enemies, or a combination of them all? Will there be a time limit? How many lives will the player have? For now, let's keep this simple: get from A to B.

Finally, give yourself a clear idea of what the level is going to look like: will it be huge and sprawling, or a Tower of Doom? If you go the latter route, you can create up to 100 floors for each level, so there's plenty of room to go nuts. That sounds good, so let's do the multiple floor thing.

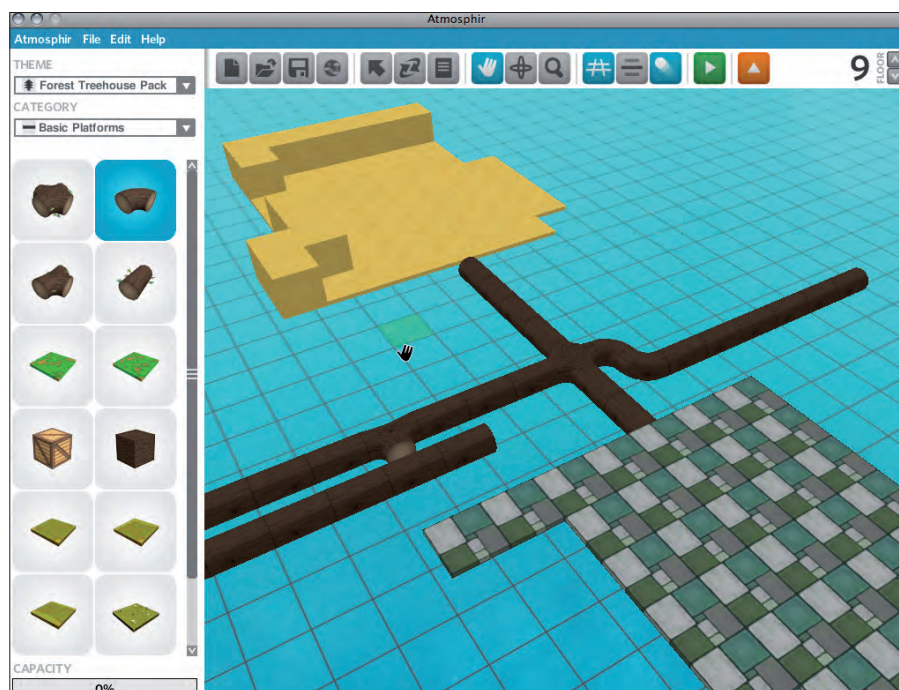
And now, to fire it up.

Getting started

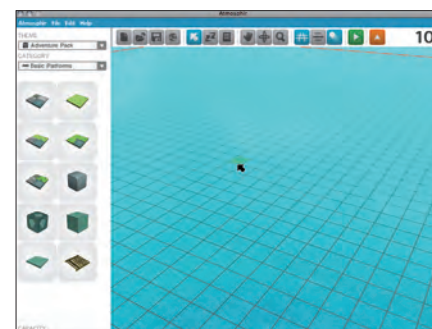
If you've used even the most basic 3D program, you should feel right at home. The panel on the left is where you'll choose the elements of your set platforms, enemies, power-ups, and such.

The big blue area in the middle is where you'll be creating your level. At the top right corner of the window, you'll see the floor (10, by default) that you're building on. At the bottom left is the Capacity bar, which tells you how much of the game engine's capacity you're hogging. As your level gets more complex, you'll need to watch this bar closely.

Let's start with creating the floor. In the left panel, select Adventure Pack under Theme, and Basic Platforms under Category. Choose the stone floor tile, and click within the scene to create it. One thing you should keep in mind is that these tiles are fairly small — your character takes roughly two steps to cross each one. As you create the



No one will grudge you your right to mix styles



Ah, that taunting blank canvas